

success MANTRA

Be ambitious, not greedy. Stand out with simplicity. People will pay for the difference.

biggest SUCCESS

Winning the Bangaram Island resort contract against the projects of major hotel chains

riskiest GAMBLE

Daring to charge \$118 as room tariff per day for their first resort on Bangaram Island



THE ECO EFFECT

Most businessmen moan about Kerala's intractable trade unionism. Not Jose Dominic, 67, a key architect of the state's tourism success story. "Kerala has only gained by refusing industries. Thanks to those red flags which drove off the smokestack invasion for Kerala remains pristine, clean and adored universally," says Dominic, who heads the CGH Earth Group, Kerala's largest hospitality chain.

Run by Dominic and his six brothers, CGH Earth has six upmarket resorts in the state and three outside. All are uniquely themed and eco-friendly. "We are against the 'Triple S' tourism—sun, sand and surf. We cater to the intelligent holidayer on a voyage of discovery," says Dominic, a chartered accountant who reluctantly left his comfortable job with AF Ferguson in Mumbai to assist his father run his 20-year-old, 32-room Casino Hotel in Kochi in 1977. "Ajit Kelkar who then headed Indian Hotels told me that I was making a big mistake by returning to Kerala to run a small hotel. He told me without scale or size or being part of an international chain, I would never grow in this industry," recalls Dominic.

Dominic then put all his energies into Casino. But the turning point came in 1988 with a Union Tourism Ministry invitation to bid to build a resort on Lakshadweep's uninhabited Bangaram Island. The big hospitality groups told the ministry that they would take three months to submit their plans, which itself would cost a few crores. Dominic said he could submit it in a day at no cost, but his guiding motto would be to not despoil the pristine island. A week later, Casino was selected from among bidders such as the Oberois and Taj. This led to the exotic Bangaram Island resort, set up with a loan of Rs 25 lakh from the state-owned Kerala Finance Corporation.

The resort was minimalist to the core. Its use was the things forbidden; no motorised water sports, no swimming pools, no television and no multi-cuisine restaurants. Staff was recruited from the uneducated local youth; they wore the traditional lungi-baniyan as uniform and wished guests in the traditional way. But the resort offered different fare—snorkelling, deep-sea fishing, ayurveda and yoga. It also had India's first formal training centre for scuba diving. "We also dared to charge \$118 per room per day making it the most expensive resort in the country. Yet the resort was full from the first month." The Bangaram model of going "green, local and upmarket" was replicated at all the CGH resorts which followed. Dominic was on the road to success. *by M.G. Radhakrishnan*